



Identifying determiners

Sometimes determiners look very similar to adjectives. One way of figuring out whether a word that precedes a noun is a determiner or an adjective is to try placing the word at the end of a sentence, following a linking verb such as *be*. If the sentence makes sense, that word is an adjective; if it does not make sense, it is a determiner.

Several furious members

This is an adjective, because the sentence makes sense.

The members **are** furious.

linking verb

This is a determiner, because the sentence does not make sense.

The members **are** **several**.



• Some words, such as **each** or **all**, are used both as **determiners** and **pronouns**. The rule to remember is that a **determiner** is **always followed by a noun**, whereas a pronoun replaces a noun.

Possessive determiners

The possessive determiners *my*, *your*, *his*, *her*, *its*, *our*, and *their* are used before nouns to show ownership. They should not be confused with possessive pronouns—for example, *mine*, *yours*, *ours*, and *theirs*—which replace, rather than precede, the noun.

their broomsticks

The broomsticks (plural noun) belong to the witches.

indefinite article

coven held **a** meeting on **their** shrieking bats!" they grumbled.

Numbers and quantifiers

Cardinal and ordinal numbers and other words that express quantity are considered to be determiners when they appear before a noun. These include *much*, *most*, *little*, *least*, *any*, *enough*, *half*, and *whole*. Beware of determiners such as *much* (singular) and *many* (plural) that can only modify singular or plural nouns.

nine shrieking bats

This cardinal number is being used before a noun phrase (*shrieking bats*) as a determiner.

much noise

This determiner can only be used with a singular noun.

many bats

This determiner can only be used with a plural noun.

Interrogative determiners

Interrogative determiners include *which* and *what* and are used before a noun to ask a question.

Which witch?

What noise?